The rebellion of 1857 also spelled the end of the East India Company. Its territories in India were put directly under government control. The Governor-General was replaced with a Viceroy, a representative of the Crown. The ratio of Europeans to Indians in the army was pushed up to 1:3 from 1:9. The British also gave up their policy of annexing Indian kingdoms, and the existing network of kingdoms and principalities was given a permanent standing under the Imperial umbrella. This framework would broadly survive till 1947. Most importantly, the Queen's Proclamation of 1858 stated that the British would no longer 'impose Our convictions on any of Our subjects.'

The Queen's Proclamation was read out by Lord Canning on 1 November 1858. The choice of place is interesting since it was not read out in Calcutta, Bombay, Madras or even Delhi. Instead, it was done in Allahabad. It is here that the Yamuna meets the Ganga and is said to be joined by the invisible Saraswati flowing underground. The place is called Triveni Sangam, literally meaning the confluence of three rivers. It is here that Ram is said to have crossed the river and visited the sage Bharadhwaj before proceeding on his exile to the forests of central India. The association with the Ramayana is remembered in a famous Hanuman temple close to Triveni Sangam and an '*eternal* tree' under which Ram is said to have rested. It is also here that Xuan Zang (or Hieun Tsang) witnessed the great gathering of the Kumbha Mela in the seventh century AD. Overlooking the temple and the merging rivers is the fort built by Emperor Akbar which houses the Mauryan column that bears the inscriptions of three emperors—Ashoka, Samudragupta and Jehangir. In short, this is no ordinary place, but the heart of Indian civilization. The British had finally understood the nature of Indian nationhood.

In order to understand the essence of this, visit the Saraswati Ghat [12] in Allahabad at dawn in January during the annual Magh Mela (or, if you are lucky, the Kumbha Mela). As the sun rises through the mist, one can see tens of thousands of people irrespective of age, gender, class, sect or caste take a dip at the confluence of the rivers. They chant Vedic hymns composed thousands of years ago on the banks of the ancient Saraswati,